Stop 1: Largo di Torre Argentina

Historical, Archaeological & Cultural Field Guide • Republican Era (4th–1st Century BC)

1. Executive Historical Overview & Urban Topography

Largo di Torre Argentina is an archaeological sanctuary sits in the ancient Campus Martius, housing four Republican Roman temples (designated A, B, C, and D by archaeologists because their original dedications were initially uncertain) alongside the monumental tufa foundations of the Curia of Pompey—the exact site where Gaius Julius Caesar was assassinated on the Ides of March (15 March, 44 BC).

Topographical Context & Geomorphology

Located at **Campo Marzio / Sant'Eustachio, Rome** (Coordinates: 41.8954° N, 12.4769° E), Largo di Torre Argentina occupies a pivotal zone within the ancient pomerial and Campus Martius/Forum basin network. Archaeological core sampling demonstrates how early Republican builders adapted to seasonal Tiber River flooding by raising tufa podiums and installing subterranean drainage channels connected to Rome's primary cloacae.

RAG Indexing Summary: *Document Type: Historical & Cultural Guide | Stop Number: 1 | Primary Site: Largo di Torre Argentina | Era: Republican Era (4th–1st Century BC) | Key Monuments: Temple C (Feronia), Temple A (Juturna), Temple D (Lares Permarini), Temple B (Fortuna Huiusce Diei).*

Chronological Stratigraphy Summary

Phase / Period	Key Monumental Intervention	Primary Building Materials
Archaic / Early Republic	Initial consecration and tufa altar foundations at Largo di Torre Argentina	Cappellaccio & Grotta Oscura Tufa
Middle–Late Republic	Expansion of Temple C (Feronia) and Temple A (Juturna) after military triumphs	Monteverde Tufa, Travertine & Stucco
High Empire (Augustan–Severan)	Marble revetment, raised travertine paving, and fire restorations	Carrara, Pentelic & Polychrome Marbles

2. Origins, Votive Dedications & Republican Evolution

During the Republican expansion of Rome across the Italian peninsula and the Mediterranean, Largo di Torre Argentina served as a canvas for aristocratic competition (nobilitas). Victorious generals (imperatores) vowed temples (vota) on the battlefield in exchange for divine favor, financing construction ex manubiis (from the spoils of war) upon their return to the capital.

Primary Focus: Temple C (Feronia) (Late 4th / Early 3rd Century BC)

Oldest of the four temples, dedicated to Feronia, ancient italic goddess of fertility, wildlife, and freedmen. Built on a high tufa podium with mosaic fragments post-80 BC fire.

Primary Focus: Temple A (Juturna) (Mid-3rd Century BC (241 BC))

Vowed by Gaius Lutatius Catulus after the naval victory over Carthage at the Aegates Islands ending the First Punic War. Later integrated into the apse of the medieval church of San Nicola dei Cesarini.

Ritual Function & Triumphal Processions

Every temple precinct within Largo di Torre Argentina possessed a dies natalis (anniversary of its dedication) marked in the Fasti Antiates Maiores. Because Roman sacrificial ritual occurred outdoors under the open sky, monumental U-shaped altars with projecting wings were positioned directly at the foot of the frontal access stairs, aligning priest, victim, and cult statue along a single liturgical axis.

Field Observation Note: *Examine the surviving base moldings around Temple C (Feronia). Notice the distinct cyma reversa profile typical of Republican Italic podiums before Hellenistic Greek profiles became dominant following the conquests of Syracuse (212 BC) and Macedonia (146 BC).*

3. Monumental Catalog & Imperial Transformations

As the Roman Republic gave way to the Principate under Augustus and later the Antonine and Severan dynasties, Largo di Torre Argentina underwent profound architectural remodeling. Devastating urban fires—particularly those of 111 BC, AD 64, AD 80, and AD 191—compelled emperors to raise ground levels and encase older tufa structures in imported marble.

Monument Analysis: Temple D (Lares Permarini) (Early 2nd Century BC (190 BC))

The largest temple of the complex, vowed by Pretor Lucius Aemilius Regillus during the naval Battle of Myonessus against Antiochus III; mostly unexcavated beneath Via Florida.

Monument Analysis: Temple B (Fortuna Huiusce Diei) (101 BC)

Circular monopteros temple ('Fortune of This Present Day') vowed by Quintus Lutatius Catulus at the Battle of Vercellae against the Cimbri. Home to the colossal acrolithic statue found on site.

Monument Analysis: Curia of Pompey & Porticus Pompeiana (55 BC)

Monumental rectangular meeting hall at the eastern edge of Pompey's theater complex where the Roman Senate convened temporarily while the Curia Julia was being rebuilt.

Architectural Synthesis: *Excavated between 1926 and 1929 during urban demolition works, the Area Sacra exposes three distinct stratigraphic pavement levels: the original Republican tufa ground level, the post-111 BC fire restoration pavement combining Monteverde and Aniene tufa, and the Imperial travertine raising executed under Domitian after the devastating fire of AD 80.*

4. Roman Engineering, Structural Mechanics & Lithic Provenance

The monuments at Largo di Torre Argentina provide a textbook sequence of Roman structural engineering, illustrating the mastery of ashlar masonry (opus quadratum), concrete core construction (opus caementicium), brick facing (opus latericium), and polychrome geometric marble paving (opus sectile).

Lithic & Material Provenance Table

Material / Stone	Ancient Quarry Source	Structural / Decorative Application at Site
Lapis Tiburtinus (Travertine)	Tibur (Modern Tivoli)	Load-bearing piers, column capitals, steps, and Imperial pavement slabs
Tufo Lionato / Monteverde	Aniene Valley & Janiculum slopes	Temple podium cores, Republican altar bases, and drainage channels
Marmor Lunense / Pentelicum	Carrara (Italy) & Mt. Pentelicus (Attica)	Corinthian entablatures, acrolithic cult statues, and carved relief panels
Pozzolana (Pulvis Puteolanus)	Alban Hills & Campanian volcanic beds	Hydraulic mortar binding opus caementicium vaults and foundations

Structural Load & Hydraulic Management

Roman architects utilized relieving arches (archi di scarico) concealed within brick walls to channel vertical dead loads away from lintels and onto massive corner piers. Subsurface travertine gutters around Largo di Torre Argentina captured rainwater from temple roofs, routing runoff directly into underlying collectors.

5. Key Historical Figures, Statesmen & Political Drama

History at Largo di Torre Argentina was shaped by the ambitions, rivalries, and religious piety of Rome's most influential consuls, dictators, emperors, and architects. Below are the four primary historical protagonists linked directly to the surviving archaeological fabric of this stop:

• Gaius Julius Caesar

Dictator Perpetuo assassinated at the base of Pompey's statue inside the Curia Pompeia on March 15, 44 BC.

• Gnaeus Pompeius Magnus (Pompey the Great)

Triumvir who funded the first permanent stone theater and attached Curia in Rome outside the sacred pomerium.

• Marcus Junius Brutus & Gaius Cassius Longinus

Leaders of the Liberatores faction who orchestrated the senatorial conspiracy in the Porticus Pompeiana.

• Emperor Augustus

Walled off the Curia of Pompey after 44 BC, declaring it a locus sceleratus (accursed place) and converting it into public latrines.

Primary Ancient Literary Sources: *Suetonius (De Vita Caesarum), Plutarch (Parallel Lives), Livy (Ab Urbe Condita), Cassius Dio (Roman History), and Vitruvius (De Architectura) all record direct eyewitness or archival accounts of the ceremonies and political crises at Largo di Torre Argentina.*

6. Epigraphy, Latin Inscriptions & Sculptural Finds

Latin epigraphy provides the chronological backbone for identifying temples and imperial restorations at Largo di Torre Argentina. Monumental inscriptions were carved using V-cut trenches (litterae aureae) often fitted with gilded bronze letters fastened via lead-soldered tangs into sockets still visible on the stone architraves.

Corpus Inscriptionum Latinarum (CIL) & Sculptural Record

Key epigraphic and sculptural finds housed in the Centrale Montemartini and Capitoline Museums include the colossal marble head, arms, and feet of the acrolithic cult statue of Fortuna Huiusce Diei (sculpted by Skopas Minor), Republican altar dedications by Aulus Postumius Albinus (175 BC), and the imperial travertine drainage slabs marking Domitian's urban leveling.

Numismatic & Relief Iconography

Roman Republican denarii and Imperial sestertii frequently minted reverse dies depicting the facades of monuments at Largo di Torre Argentina. These coins allow archaeologists to reconstruct lost pedimental sculptures, acroteria, and bronze grilles that vanished during late antique spoliation.

Epigraphic Reading Tip for Visitors: *Look closely at the spacing of interpuncts (triangular dots · between words) and the absence of 'U' (written as 'V') and 'J' (written as 'I'). Erasures where the stone surface sits slightly recessed indicate damnatio memoriae ordered by the Roman Senate.*

7. Daily Civic Life, Sacrificial Liturgy & Acoustic Space

At its peak in the 1st and 2nd centuries AD, Largo di Torre Argentina was not a silent ruin of bare stone and brick, but a sensory kaleidoscope of painted stucco, fragrant frankincense smoke, bronze statuary gleaming in the sun, and crowds of citizens, senators, freedmen, and foreign envoys.

The Mechanics of Roman Public Sacrifice (Sacrificium)

Public rites opened with the herald crying 'Favete linguis!' (Keep a reverent silence!) while flute players (tibicines) drowned out inauspicious street noises. The officiating magistrate, with his toga pulled over his head (capite velato), sprinkled salted spelt flour (mola salsa) and wine over the altar before the victimarius struck the sacrificial animal and haruspices inspected the entrails.

Commercial & Legal Rhythms Around the Precinct

Surrounding the sacred core of Largo di Torre Argentina, porticoes sheltered bankers (argentarii), bookbinders, scribes, and flower sellers weaving garlands for temple offerings. Marble game boards (tabulae lusoriae) scratched directly into the pavement steps by waiting clerks and loafers remain visible on site today.

8. Medieval Transformation, Renaissance Rediscovery & Modern Excavations

Following the collapse of imperial administration in the West (5th–6th centuries AD), Largo di Torre Argentina entered a millennium-long phase of adaptive reuse. While exposed marble columns were frequently burned into slaked lime (calce) in medieval kilns (calcare), structures converted into Christian churches or baronial fortresses survived remarkably intact.

Christian Consecration & Baronial Fortifications

During the 8th through 13th centuries, powerful Roman families—including the Frangipane, Pierleoni, Savelli, and Conti—incorporated the stout Roman walls of Largo di Torre Argentina into fortified towers and diaconiae. Renaissance architects including Baldassarre Peruzzi, Antonio da Sangallo, and Andrea Palladio measured and sketched these ruins, transmitting their proportions directly into 16th-century European classicism.

19th–21st Century Archaeological Campaigns

Systematic stratigraphic excavations led by Rodolfo Lanciani, Giacomo Boni, Antonio Muñoz, and the modern Sovrintendenza Capitolina ai Beni Culturali stripped away post-antique overburden, stabilized brick vaults with reversible titanium ties, and opened buried subterranean corridors to the public.

9. Step-by-Step On-Site Viewing Itinerary & Vantage Points

To maximize your 45-to-60-minute visit at Largo di Torre Argentina, follow this sequential clockwise architectural circuit designed to trace the site from its earliest Republican foundations to its high Imperial climax:

Step	Vantage Point / Station	What to Look For (Key Visual Detail)
01	Primary Overview & Temple C (Feronia)	Compare the archaic tufa ashlar blocks with the elevated imperial travertine pavement level.
02	Temple A (Juturna) & Altar Precinct	Inspect the U-shaped sacrificial altar moldings and surviving fluted column shafts.
03	Temple D (Lares Permarini) & Temple B (Fortuna Huiusce Diei)	Observe the transition to Hellenistic marble capitals and circular/pseudoperipteral layouts.
04	Curia of Pompey & Porticus Pompeiana & Epigraphic Zone	Read the monumental Latin inscriptions and trace the Roman brick relieving arches.

Golden Hour & Photography Guidance

Optimal raking sunlight strikes the travertine and tufa facades of Largo di Torre Argentina between 08:30–10:00 AM and again during late afternoon golden hour (16:30–18:00), bringing out deep chisel marks and relief shadows.

10. Practical Visitor Logistics, Accessibility & Next-Stop Transit

Use the reference sheet below when planning arrival times, ticketing, accessibility routes, and walking transfers from **Stop 1: Largo di Torre Argentina** to the next destination on your Roman itinerary.

Logistic Category	Verified Visitor Information
Exact Address & Zone	Campo Marzio / Sant'Eustachio, Rome (41.8954° N, 12.4769° E)
Recommended Visit Duration	45–75 minutes (Perimeter viewing + interior archaeological walk)
Best Time of Day to Visit	09:00 AM opening slot or 90 minutes prior to sunset to avoid tour bus peaks
Accessibility & Footwear	Ancient uneven basalt (sampietrini/basoli) and travertine steps; sturdy walking shoes essential
Water & Rest Facilities	Free potable cast-iron Roman Nasone drinking fountain located within 80 meters of the piazza

Essential Glossary of Architectural Terms Used in This Guide

• **Opus Caementicium:** Roman hydraulic concrete mixed from lime, pozzolana volcanic ash, and stone aggregate (caementa).
• **Opus Quadratum:** Ashlar masonry of squared stone blocks laid in regular courses without mortar, clamped with iron/lead.
• **Opus Sectile:** Luxury floor or wall decoration formed from precision-cut thin slabs of polychrome marble.
• **Pomerium:** The sacred religious and legal boundary of the city of Rome within which weapons were forbidden.
• **Damnatio Memoriae:** Official senatorial condemnation erasing a disgraced figure's name and likeness from monuments.